

NORAD: Deepened China-Russia military cooperation increases threats to U.S. homeland

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FULL TEXT

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The likelihood of direct military conflict between the U.S. and its top adversaries is growing, fueled by deepening strategic cooperation between China, Russia, North Korea and Iran, according to the head of the North American Aerospace Defense Command (NORAD) and U.S. Northern Command (NORTHCOM).

Air Force Gen. Gregory Guillot warned that these adversaries are expanding their military capabilities and strengthening ties in ways that directly threaten the U.S. homeland in Feb. 13 written testimony prepared for the Senate Armed Services Committee. He described a broad coordinated effort among America's adversaries that could escalate a regional conflict into a global one.

"The likelihood of direct conflict between the United States and one of its four principal adversaries is increasing," Guillot testified. "Strategic cooperation among these adversaries has grown substantially since the beginning of the Ukraine war, increasing the risk that war with one adversary could quickly expand into war with an enemy coalition." The testimony underscores how U.S. defense officials are recalibrating their threat assessments to account for not just China's growing military power but also the potential for coordinated operations with Russia and North Korea. The shift marks a significant evolution in strategic concerns as adversaries that have historically acted independently are now leveraging each other's military assets and expertise to challenge the U.S. and its allies.

One of the major developments highlighted by Guillot is the closer military collaboration between China and Russia. In the summer of 2024, he said China deployed bomber aircraft to a Russian Arctic airbase for the first time and conducted a joint bomber patrol over the Bering Sea alongside Russian heavy bombers.

"Such 'access transfer' accelerates and extends China's ability to threaten North America in the air domain and raises the specter of coordinated military operations in the event of a strategic conflict," Guillot testified.

The move represents a shift in China's military posture, he said. While Beijing has historically focused its military modernization on regional conflicts, its expanded presence in the Arctic and North Pacific suggests a broader strategic intent. If China gains routine access to Russian airbases and naval ports in the Arctic, it could significantly shorten the time required to launch strikes against North American targets, according to the four-star general. Meanwhile, North Korea has also demonstrated its willingness to support Russia's war in Ukraine, with Pyongyang reportedly supplying military personnel and munitions to Moscow. Guillot cautioned this growing partnership raises concerns about potential technology transfers that could accelerate North Korea's weapons development -- particularly its strategic missile and cyber capabilities.

While the Pentagon has long tracked China's nuclear modernization, Guillot's testimony pointed to an increasing threat from conventional Chinese weapon systems that can strike U.S. territory. Over the past year, China has:

- * Deployed warships to the Bering Sea for the fourth consecutive year, operating within cruise missile range of critical infrastructure in Alaska.
- * Expanded its fleet of Shang III-class nuclear-powered guided-missile submarines (SSGNs) which in the coming years could provide Beijing a clandestine land-attack capability against the U.S. West Coast.
- * Integrated air-refuellable H-6N bombers into joint Sino-Russian bomber patrols extending China's ability to conduct long-range strikes without needing forward bases.

* Developed conventionally armed intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs) which could allow China to strike U.S. territory without crossing the nuclear threshold.

Guillot emphasized China's advancements in these areas "increase the likelihood that an armed conflict would include direct strikes on the homeland." The ability to hold U.S. infrastructure at risk with conventional weapons provides Beijing with an escalation option that falls between cyberattacks and nuclear strikes, complicating U.S. strategic decision-making.

China's development of new nuclear delivery systems also poses fresh challenges for U.S. early warning and missile defense systems. According to Guillot, China is refining its ability to field nuclear-armed ICBMs equipped with hypersonic glide vehicles (HGVs) or capable of following a fractional orbital bombardment system (FOBS) trajectory. These systems which can approach North America from the south rather than the traditional northern vector are designed to evade U.S. early warning radars.

"Such systems, if fielded, would erode strategic stability by degrading our ability to provide granular and actionable warning of an inbound attack," Guillot warned.

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